

Finding My Place

I followed the team through the RSI locker room. Danni got a few smiles and a shout out or two from her teammates on the way through, but everyone is well-aware that Trish doesn't fuck around when it comes to performing her post-fight examination. Was anything seriously wrong with Danni? Highly unlikely. Cole may have hit her with three rounds of frustration, but she never really did much hitting with her fists. But Trish had a job to do, and the women of RSI knew not to interfere. Celebrate however you want after she gives the green light, but stay the hell out of the way until then.

Danni, Trish and Marcy marched straight into one of the training rooms and closed the door. I stayed outside with Steph and Amanda.

I could literally feel the rest of the stable waiting on the other side of the lockers, but they gave us our space, for now.

"You alright?" Steph asked.

I turned around to find she was looking at me.

"Me? I'm fine. What the hell would be wrong with me?"

Which was kind of a lie because something was wrong with me. I just couldn't quite put my finger on what it was.

"Danni wanted you in there," Amanda said.

"I know. I just... it's complicated, and I didn't want to step on her moment."

"What's complicated?" she asked. "She wanted you there."

Steph was lined up right behind her. I suddenly realized I was being interrogated.

I was tempted to lash out, but Steph's presence made me hold my tongue. She's not one to stick her nose in other people's business... so what was this, then?

I'll never know why, but my eyes drifted over to a bench beside the lockers... and I suddenly understood.

Not all that long ago, we had all been here in Australia when Danni faced Cheryl Cole. Afterward, we found ourselves gathered in the locker room... where Steph and I sat on a bench just like that one and waited for Trish to come out and tell us exactly how badly Danni had been beaten.

Shortly after that, all hell had suddenly broken loose.

Everything was different this time... except that I was acting weird and even I wasn't sure why.

"Everything is fine," I said. "There's nothing to worry about."

"And the 'complications?'" Steph asked.

"I shouldn't have said that. There's nothing complicated."

Then I smiled and added, "It's just none of your business."

Mandy smiled back. Steph doesn't smile much, but she nodded as though she found my answer acceptable.

Everyone was content... except maybe me. I was just... I don't know.

The door to the training room opened. Trish stepped out. Marcy followed and carefully closed the door behind her.

The scene evoked more memories of last time, but the report was a total reversal.

"All good," Trish said. "She'll go on the inactive list because it's protocol, but there's no cause for concern. None at all."

I looked to Marcy.

"I had nothing to do," she shrugged, then held her kit up for us to see. "I didn't even open it."

Four and a half rounds, and not a damn thing wrong with her. The news couldn't have been better. But my emotions were still wrong. I was supposed to be happy. I WAS happy. I could feel it deep inside me, but I couldn't seem to let it out.

"Can we go in?" I asked.

"All yours," Trish said.

I looked at Steph and Amanda.

"You first," Steph said. "We'll wait here."

I nodded, then turned to the door and reached for the knob. Just like last time.

The door opened. Once more, nothing was the same.

The lights were all on, reflecting sharply off the polished tile and metal cabinetry. In the center of everything sat Danni, with her legs dangling loosely over the side of the training table.

She was still in the RSI bra and shorts she'd worn for the fight, colored in our signature red on black style. The exertion of battle still showed in the way her skin glistened and the slightly wild look of her hair.

To me, she looked perfect.

I stood there for a while, just absorbing the scene. Then I stepped in and closed the door.

She was too perfect. It was too much for me to stand.

"So, how did I do?" she asked.

"I told..."

My voice caught in my throat. My cheeks were suddenly wet.

Jesus... I was crying.

"Richelle..."

I put a hand up to signal that I just needed a minute. She had fought long and hard for this, and I'd be damned if I was going to fuck it up for her.

I took a deep breath and pulled it together.

"I told you you would make us all proud."

The words came out clear and strong, despite the tears. And saying them aloud helped me get my emotions in line. Because I WAS proud... and that was part of the problem.

"How did you do it?" I asked. "How did you manage this?"

I didn't say everything I was thinking because I couldn't find the words. I knew the depth of the hole she'd been in. And yes, I had jumped in with her to show her the way out, but... now we were someplace I had never been. She'd climbed out of the hole, and then scaled some sort of insurmountable mountain. Not back to where she was, but beyond it by miles. How had that happened?

But I was thinking about more than just her comeback. I was thinking of who she was and the million little things she does just right and the way she inspires the people around her to not only be better but to help others be better, too.

What I should have asked is how she'd managed to become the beautiful person she was.

"I had a lot of help," she said.

Same old Danni. Always deferring credit.

"Speaking of which," she continued, "coming down there like that couldn't have been an easy decision."

"It was a lot easier than you'd think," I said.

With no conscious thought, I moved a couple of steps toward her. Letting the magnetism pull me in.

So god-damned proud...

"You're lucky Steph didn't kill you," she said.

I'm sure she meant it as a joke, but I tried to stumble my way through a response anyway.

"I didn't... I worried about Steph a little, but..."

Something clicked in my head and the whole scene changed.

I took a few more steps.

"I suddenly realized where I needed to be," I said. "Nothing was going to stop me after that."

I heard a change in my voice that went along with the change in my head. And I was still moving. One small step at a time.

She sat up straight and made room as I stepped into her. She seemed to know what was happening better than I did.

I pressed in close. Our faces only inches apart.

For a brief moment, we looked straight into each other. Both of us knew what was about to happen, and neither did anything to stop it.

And then we kissed.

I don't know exactly who started it, and I don't care. But it was powerful and deep and it felt like the most natural thing I'd ever done. Not just natural, but necessary. Like breathing. I didn't understand how I'd survived so long without it.

The kiss got stronger. She curled an arm behind my back and pulled me forward. I braced my hands on the table and pushed up into her. We couldn't physically get any closer, but we were still trying.

We came up for air, but I didn't want to stop. I kissed her chin... her cheek... along the side of her neck and up to her ear.

"Fuck you, Danni," I said in a soft, breathless whisper that did not fit with what I was saying. "Fuck you and your relentless, selfless, nauseating perfection. How am I ever supposed to be worthy of you?"

There was no anger in my words. I just... said them. But... why? I hadn't been thinking that... had I?

Maybe I had. Maybe that was it, all along. Because I was so proud and so impressed... not just today, but every day. And I didn't understand. I didn't know how I could be who I was and have done the things that I'd done and still be deserving of a person like her.

She got a grip on the lapels of my blouse, then slid off the table and spun me against the wall. She didn't look too happy... because we had been down this road before.

"I don't ever want to hear you say that again," she said. "I'm not going to let you hide behind this sob story, anymore. You're worthy because I said so. I decide what I want... and I want you. If you don't feel the same, then tell me now. Otherwise, shut up. Do you understand me?"

My mouth hung open as I gave her a dazed nod.

She kissed me again - probably making sure I didn't get another chance to say something stupid. But I had nothing I wanted to say.

I'm not good at taking advice, and I'm fully aware that I actively discourage people from giving me any. But Danni has long been one of the few who were willing to put me in my place. The first time she did it, it changed the way I viewed her forever. And that was nothing compared to this moment, right here.

No... this one had me thinking she might just be the hottest thing on god's green Earth.

Without breaking the kiss, I turned us around and put her on the wall. I don't know why. To show her, maybe? Because I did feel the same, and I wanted her to know it. I wanted her to feel me standing here. With her. Not running away.

Never again.

Then she swam an arm inside, got a handful of my shirt and forced me back as we kissed our way across to the opposite wall. Taking back control. Showing me that even if I wanted to run, she wasn't going to let me.

It wasn't lost on me that we were using fight techniques in the middle of a moment that was supposed to be tender and passionate, but I can't say it didn't feel right.

I pushed off the wall and tried to turn us around again. I guess I surprised her because she slipped and both of us stumbled into the table, sending instruments scattering everywhere.

The crashing and clanging was like a cup of cold water thrown in my face.

I pulled away suddenly.

"We can't do this," I said.

"Richelle, I swear..."

"No... I mean, we *CAN'T* do this. Steph and Mandy are standing on the other side of that door. There's a whole locker room full of women waiting for you. Not to mention the press."

No sooner had I said it when there was a knock at the door.

"You guys OK?" Mandy asked.

"Yeah... it's fine. I just knocked some stuff over," I called back. "I'll be out in a minute."

I turned to Danni, who looked both surprised at how easily we'd forgotten where we were, and annoyed that we couldn't just go back and forget again.

I scooped up the spilled tools and put them back where they came from.

She grabbed my hand and reeled me into her. Body to body. Face to face.

"Promise me," she said.

She didn't have to explain. We had waited a long time and been through a ton of shit to get to this point... and most of it had come from me. Now, here we were... standing right on the edge... and she wanted to make sure I wasn't going to shrink back and find some new reason for delay.

I nodded.

"I promise," I said.

It was an easy promise to make. I was done waiting. I wanted to jump.

I kissed her again. Hard and fast. Then I pushed my way free before we forgot ourselves again.

I looked at her for a long while.

"That conversation we were going to have..." she began.

"I think we just had it," I said.

Another moment passed as she added up the details of what happened that night in her kitchen.

"You've been carrying this for a while," she concluded.

"Not nearly as long as you."

She smiled, and all I wanted to do was kiss her again. I inched forward, then had to dig my heel hard against the tile to stop myself.

"And the part about where we go from here?" she asked.

"I'm going wherever you're going," I answered. "Today, tomorrow and every day after that."

Who was this person I heard talking? She sounded a lot like me, but she was saying really weird shit.

We looked at each other some more. The pull I felt was unbelievable. I was on the verge of losing it. The look on her face told me she was, too.

"I gotta get the hell out of here," I said.

"Yeah..."

I opened the door and used my grip on the knob to propel myself out of the room. Practically running away... which was just what Steph and Mandy didn't want to see. But I couldn't worry about making the right impression. I just had to go.

I headed for the little office. Forgetting there was a locker room full of women between here and there.

"Hey!" Britney called out when she saw me. "How is she?"

All eyes turned to me. The whole stable, primed and ready for a celebration.

To me, they felt like a firing squad.

"She's good," I said. "Perfect, actually."

"Well, where is she?"

"She's in with Steph and Mandy. She should be out any minute."

Good job, I credited myself. Short, sweet and on point. Perfectly handled.

Except nobody moved.

"You OK?" Elisha asked.

"Of course," I lied. "Why?"

"You look like you've been crying."

So much for perfect.

I scrambled for a believable answer and came up empty. Then Danni stepped around the corner, and every single soul in the room forgot I was there. The noise was deafening. They surged in at her like a mob... the cheering and yelling blending together until I couldn't understand a word anyone was saying. But the message was still crystal clear.

Their leader officially had her groove back.

The chaos made it easy for me to fade to the back, where I stood off to the side and watched for a while. It was awesome to see. Like being in the presence of a rock star. Everyone seemed desperate to get even a few seconds with her. Even the rookies. Despite her natural humility, Danni was drinking it in. Not because she thought she was deserving of the attention, but because these were her friends and she wanted to celebrate with them.

And yet, I couldn't help noticing the way her eyes kept clicking back to me.

Did she know what she was doing to me? Or maybe... were we doing it to each other?

Either way, I couldn't stand it, so I went back to plan A and hid in the office... where I spent my time imagining a long, cold shower.